hold a massive rally; the rally must play in a 360-degree spin across media platforms—live television, Internet, social media, mobile applications.

We aren't yet a tele-democracy in the American style. Nor is media spin enough to turn an election. Indian elections are still won and lost on a complex interplay of local-level allegiances and a robust organizational machinery on the ground. But while your debating skills on prime time won't prove decisive, they are a useful weapon to possess on the electoral battlefield. News television can set the agenda—it may be awfully noisy, but it is heard.

Many years ago, a veteran Congress politician, the late V.N. Gadgil, had lamented that he no longer felt suited to be a party spokesperson. 'I speak for thirty minutes—you reduce it to a thirty-second sound bite,' he told me. We are becoming a sound-bite society—short, sharp quotes are preferred to any long-winded manifesto. I sometimes wonder if anyone these days reads party manifestos before they go to vote.

It's not just the sound-bite age—it is the era of marketing. The year 2014 marks a coming-of-age moment for political advertising. Yes, we've had ad campaigns—most notably in the 1984 elections—that did create a flutter, but the kind of sustained hype we've witnessed this time is unmatched. Hoardings, billboards, news and entertainment channels, newspapers, radio—if you spent eight weeks in India between March and May, you'd think politics was the only 'product' on sale. Like television, advertising won't make or break an election verdict, but like the rest of the media, it can help create the 'surround sound', the election *mahaul* (atmosphere). The BJP's ad line—'*Achhe Din Aanewale Hain*' (Good Days Are Coming)—has now stuck in public consciousness. When India won a Test match at Lords in July 2014, the Hindi commentator was ecstatic. '*Achhe din aa gaye,*' he exulted.

But elections, above all else, are made by personalities, or, as in the 2014 elections, by a clash of personalities. Narendra Modi versus Rahul Gandhi—the *pracharak* versus the prince, the 'outsider' versus the 'insider', the meritocrat versus the dynast, the small-town tea boy versus the child of elite privilege. We love a Hindi film where two sharply contrasted individuals